

The coverage of Gavin Newsom in recent media: a study of tone and topic

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Introduction

Gavin Newsom, the 40th governor of California and a Democrat, has been a prominent figure in American politics for over two decades. First rising to national attention during his tenure as Mayor of San Francisco in the early 2000s, Newsom gained widespread recognition for authorizing same-sex marriage licenses in 2004, positioning himself as a progressive political actor. Since becoming governor in 2019, he has continued to attract significant public and media scrutiny positioning himself for a future federal office.

We were hired by a media organization to examine how the American news media portrays Gavin Newsom. **Our report analyzes recent English-language coverage from news outlets across the United States (U.S), investigating the topics most commonly associated with Newsom and determining whether the coverage tends to be positive, negative or neutral.**

Given Newsom's recent emergence as a prominent political figure, our stakeholders may be interested in understanding whether Newsom primarily is portrayed through the lens of California governance, national politics positioning, public controversies, or personality-driven narratives.

To provide clarity for stakeholders, we define several key terms:

"Gavin Newsom coverage" refers to articles that mention Newsom by name in the title or the opening of the article. The coverage may extend beyond Newsom himself and include his administration, allies, critics, or political implications of his actions. This broader approach reflects the fact that public perception of a political figure is shaped by policy decisions, institutional dynamics, and commentary from both supporters and opponents.

"Recent" refers to a timeframe of approximately 1 month, starting on October 21st, 2025 and ending on November 25th, 2025

"American news outlets" include U.S based, English-language news sources with online publishing platforms.

After analyzing 500 articles that meet our criteria, we present a set of key findings:

(1) News outlets most frequently frame Newsom as a national political actor rather than primarily as California's governor. (2) Coverage of Newsom's public image is polarized compared to other categories. A single high-profile event can disproportionately shape Newsom's media portrayal, for example, a scandal involving his former chief of staff generated widespread attention and drove negative tone despite not involving Newsom directly. (3) Trump is monopolizing a significant portion of the media coverage of Gavin Newsom; references to Trump appear across a wide range of topics, even in categories with otherwise very different thematic focuses.

Data

Our dataset records key data on 500 articles. There are 7 columns: title, body, source, category, P/N/Ne and date, defined as follows:

- *Title*: the title of the news article.
- *Body*: the first 5 sentences of the article
- *Source*: the name of the news provider that published the article
- *Category*: the topic of the article's content. Human-annotated inferred feature.
- *Sentiment*: positive/negative/neutral, referring to the article's tone with respect to Gavin Newsom. Human-annotated inferred feature.
- *Date*: date of each article
- *Publisher_leaning*: the political leaning of the publishing source for the article. Human-annotated feature.¹

We created this dataset through the NEWS API. The API came with several constraints that shaped our design decisions: (1) The API's lookback period is limited to 30 days, (2) The API doesn't include every news provider, (3) The API does not always return articles about Gavin Newsom.

The exclusion criteria for our data was not using the English language, not being published by a news source established in the U.S, being published before October 21st, not mentioning ‘Newsom’ in the title or first 5 sentences of the articles to address constraints (1) and (3).

Our aim when collecting data was to prioritize newspapers sources that had the most readers in the U.S as it represents the media coverage of G. Newsom that has the largest impact on the American population². At first, we ran a stratified sampling, selecting the articles of the most read newspapers while keeping a balanced distribution of left, centrist and right leaning sources.

However, another challenge during data collection was the need to remove duplicate articles, since news outlets often repost the same piece multiple times. We also observed that some newspapers simply republished wire-service content from AP News or Reuters without adding original reporting. This filtering step eliminated more than half of the initial results, which forced us to conduct additional collection rounds and expand our set of sources beyond only the most widely read outlets.

After data collection and filtering, our dataset was composed of 500 articles from 35 different newspaper sources. 8 sources were considered left leaning (23%), 11 as center-left leaning (32%), 5 as centrist and center-right leaning (14% each), and 6 as right leaning (17%). Throughout the dataset, 22.8% of articles were considered Left leaning, 39.3% Center-left leaning, 5.2% as Centrist, 4.4% Center-right leaning and 28.3% Right leaning. The skew in the sample may be explained by two facts. First, Democrats are more likely than Republicans and GOP-leaning independents to use and trust a number of major news sources³. This makes for an overrepresentation of Center-left leaning news sources in the U.S. Secondly, the Center-left leaning news sources tend to be bigger newspapers, which in turn, publish a larger number of articles compared to less followed newspapers. The skew in our sample can therefore be explained by a bias in the news sourcing in the U.S rather than a bias in our sampling, and keeping it as such makes for a more representative dataset.

We acknowledge limitations in our sampling that stem from the use of APIs. As mentioned in constraint (2), we noticed that several major news outlets, such as CNN were not present in the API we have picked, which may influence our analysis.

Methods

Methods:

Developing a Typology:

We annotated two inferred features: *category* and *sentiment*. Beginning with open coding on an initial set of 200 articles, we refined our classifications through three rounds of coding before arriving at the final typology. First, we

independently annotated 50 entries each, without communication. This produced 10 preliminary categories, which we merged into 8 after discussion. During the second annotation phase, we found that some categories were poorly defined or too vague. We then refined them into more specific, clearer categories. Finally, we conducted a third round of annotation, which confirmed that the revised typology worked consistently and without major issues.

Positive/negative/neutral tone:

Assessing an article’s tone towards Newsom had inherent subjectivity risks, as what is “positive”, “negative”, or “neutral” is subject to individual interpretation. We created tone definitions and had one person annotate all articles to limit variance. Tone was categorized by: archetype (e.g. “victor”, “memelord”: positive. “coward”, “fool”: negative), writing style (e.g. triumphant: positive, clinical: neutral, sarcastically critical: negative) and reporting choice (e.g. Obama’s endorsement: positive. e.g. Podcaster’s criticism: negative.) There was also a broad judgement made of whether the article was encouraging voters to vote for Newsom and praising his work or discouraging voters and disparaging his policies.

These categorization choices were made to reduce vagueness and subjectivity, while also focusing on relevant perceptions for a politician: character and effectiveness.

Term Frequency-Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF):

To ensure accurate TF-IDF calculations, a text preprocessing pipeline was implemented with entity normalization as the core component. Manual entity normalization was selected over automated Named Entity Recognition due to superior performance with political terminology and domain-specific language patterns. For example, word tokens "immigration", "immigrant", "immigrants", "undocumented", "border" were normalized to an `immigration_entity`. The preprocessing pipeline applied entity normalization before text cleaning to preserve semantic groupings. Regular expressions with word boundaries ensured precise matching while preventing unintended substring replacements.

The TF-IDF vectorizer was extensively optimized through parameter variation to ensure the most accurate term representation and to avoid omitting important thematic concepts from the article corpus. A size of 1000 features was used to limit vocabulary to the most significant terms. To be included a term would have to appear in at least 2 documents to reduce noise. Terms that appeared >80% of articles were emitted to remove overly common words for example, Gavin Newsom - a term which would not offer important information for analysis. Lastly, only unigrams were used by the vectorizer since entity normalisation handled multi-word terms. Additionally custom news-specific stop words were included.

It should be noted that manual entity mapping requires highly contextual design decisions to achieve accurate normalization. For example, deciding whether the term “president” should be normalized to trump_entity or not, requires a high-level of familiarity with the data to reflect its handling of the term. Furthermore, this method requires maintenance as new political figures or terminology emerge.

LLM:

To produce LLM-generated summaries of the categorized data, *Claude Sonnet 4* was prompted to concisely summarise each dataset based on key topics, characteristics, themes and patterns present.

Methods

Developing a Typology:

Through the development of our typology (see “Methods”); we selected the following eight categories:

1. **Climate & Energy:** Articles centred on climate policy, environment actions, or energy-related decisions. This includes reporting on oil, renewable energy initiatives, and international climate events. Example: California’s climate leadership, oil drilling disputes
2. **Corruption & Scandal:** Coverage involving alleged misconduct, corruption, or ethical violations. These articles may concern Newsom directly or focus on individuals within his political orbit, since scandals involving close affiliates can meaningfully shape his public image. Example: Articles about fundraising irregularities.
3. **Economy:** Articles whose main focus is economic policy or conditions at the local, national, or international level. This includes taxation, labor markets, cost of living, housing, and regulation. Issues that mention climate or social dynamics are only included here if the central issue remains economic. Example: billionaire tax proposals.
4. **Immigration & Security:** Coverage relating to immigration policy, targeting of immigrants, policing, and broader security issues. This includes both state and federal-level conflicts, especially when Newsom responds to or challenges national directives. Example: ICE enforcement.
5. **National Politics:** Articles relevant to American politics beyond California, including federal policy debates, Democratic Party dynamics, and all coverage involving Newsom’s possible presidential ambitions. This category includes national events even when Newsom is not the main subject, as long as he is meaningfully involved or positioned within the national discussion. Example: presidential race strategies.

6. **Public Image:** Articles that focus on Newsom’s personal character, leadership style, personality traits, or rhetorical behavior, rather than the impacts of his policies. This includes opinion pieces assessing his demeanor, ambition, or perceived strengths and weaknesses. Example: Twitter Clash with Trump.
7. **Local Politics:** Coverage specific to California governance, policies, or state political dynamics. This includes California elections, ballot propositions, legislation, and state-level administrative decisions. National implications may be mentioned, but the core emphasis is on California itself. Example: state ballot initiatives.
8. **Social Issues:** Articles concerning social policy domains such as healthcare, abortion rights, discrimination, welfare, or gun policy. Immigration-specific content is excluded unless framed as part of a broader social justice discussion. Example: Newsom policy to improve pay equity and wage transparency.

Topic presentation:

After running the TF-IDF on our 8 categories, the results seen in Figure 1 were produced.

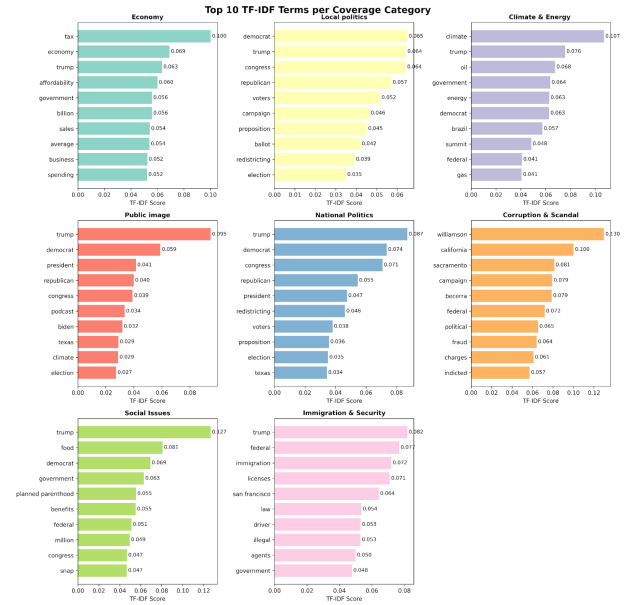


Fig. 1. Top ten most important words for each of our typology’s categories as determined by TF-IDF.

Analysis of the TF-IDF scores reveals several key patterns in the news coverage of Governor Newsom across the eight thematic categories. First, a high degree of thematic overlap is observed, particularly between “Public Image” and “National Politics,” where the top terms are highly similar. Second, the term “Trump” demonstrates exceptional presence across the entire corpus, ranking in the

top 3 Tf-idf terms in seven out of the eight topics and securing the number one position in four topics (Local Politics, Public Image, National Politics, and Immigration and Security). Third, the highest Tf-idf score overall belongs to the term "corruption" in the "Corruption/Scandal" topic (0.330), followed by "tax" in "Economy" (0.109) and "climate" in "Climate & Energy" (0.207), demonstrating high distinctiveness for these specific policy and scandal terms. Finally, topics that are typically state-focused, such as "Local Politics" and "Immigration and Security," prominently feature national political terms like "Trump," "federal," "republican," and "congress" among their top weighted terms.

The LLM-generated summaries largely reinforce the TF-IDF results by highlighting the same dominant patterns (See Appendix). While TF-IDF captures the lexical structure of each topic, the LLM adds interpretive framing that helps contextualize those terms. However, the LLM should be used only as a complement to TF-IDF, not as a standalone method, as it can occasionally over-interpret the data and draw conclusions that require further validation.

Topics engagement:

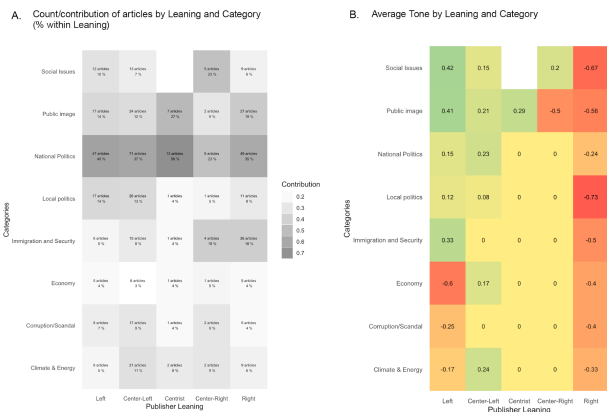


Fig. 2. Articles' overall sentiment about Newsom and distribution of the coverage topics according to the topic covered (following our typology) and the political leaning of the publisher of the article.

A. The figure on the left indicates the number of articles for each category and political leaning, the representative percentage within that political leaning is shown as a number and with the opacity of the cell (transparent=small contribution, opaque=more contribution).

B. The figure on the right represents the overall sentiment about Newsom in the articles (red=negative, yellow=neutral, green= positive). (n=500).

Distribution across political leaning:

Because of the difference in the number of articles published across political leaning categories, we analysed the distribution of topics within each political leaning.

The importance given to each topic (see Topics Presentations for definitions) varied across political leaning of the article's publisher, although some dynamics remained consistent across all leanings. We found that all political leanings had a majority of articles about National Politics. For Centrist, Center-right and Right sources, the second highest was Public Image while it was Local Politics for Center Left sources and Left leaning sources had both equally as representative. We found major difference in the coverage of the topic of Immigration & Security which was significantly engaged with by Right and Center-Right leaning articles (Right: 18.4%; Center-Right: 18.2%) while it was less represented in other political leanings (Centrist: 3.8%; Center-left: 7.8%; Left: 5.1%). Climate & Energy was more covered by Center leaning sources (Center-left: 10.9%; Center-right: 9.1%; Centrist: 7.7%) when compared to more polarized sources (Left: 5.1%; Right: 6.4%). Corruption & Scandal were the 6th most represented topic while Economy was consistently the last.

Finally, we noticed that Center-Left and Center-right had a more evenly distributed coverage of topics when compared to Centrist or polarized articles.

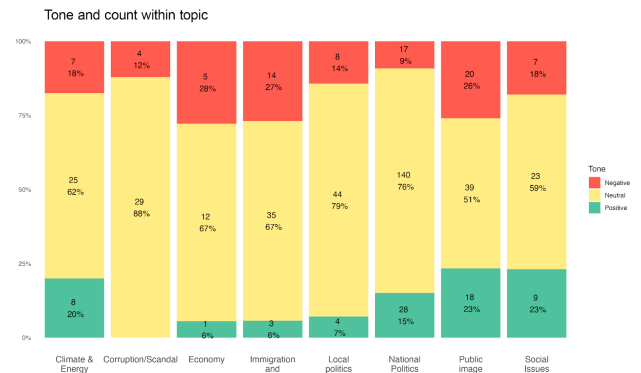


Fig. 3. Articles' overall sentiment about Newsom per topic (following our topology) across all the data (n=500).

Tone across political leaning:

Across the entire dataset, 69% of articles were neutral, 16% negative, and 14% positive. Tone varied substantially across topics: negative sentiment was more common in Economy (28%), Immigration & Security (28%), and Public Image (26%), while positive sentiment was higher in Climate & Energy (20%), Public Image (23%), and Social Issues (23%). These differences reflected the distribution of coverage across political leanings, with Immigration & Security covered more heavily by right-leaning outlets and Climate & Energy more heavily by left-leaning outlets.

Tone also diverged strongly depending on the political leaning of the publisher. Left-leaning outlets tended to be more positive toward Newsom, right-leaning outlets more

negative, and centrist outlets largely neutral. 78% of all right-leaning articles were negative, with *Breitbart* and the *New York Post* accounting for more than half of these cases. Polarization was especially pronounced in National Politics and Public Image, two topics with heavy coverage across all leanings: left and center-left outlets were generally positive, while center-right and right outlets were predominantly negative. Similar patterns appeared in Immigration & Security and Social Issues. In contrast, Economy, Corruption & Scandal, and Climate & Energy were mostly neutral or negative across leanings, with the exception that center-left outlets showed more positive tone in Climate & Energy and Economic coverage.

Discussion

From our results, we gathered two main findings.

The first one is that media outlets with different political leanings focus their coverage of Newsom on different topics and different tones, revealing a polarized media landscape in which outlets emphasize issue areas aligned with their ideological preferences. Overall, all political leanings devoted most of their coverage to National Politics, which reflects Newsom's rising potential as a Democratic runner-up for the next presidential election. However, beyond this shared focus, patterns diverged. Right leaning articles focused more on topics like Immigration & Security or Public Image, which have long held strategic importance for conservative media. Immigration has become a core mobilizing issue about Republican voters, which often has garnered critiques of Democratic governance in border enforcement, crime, and budget spending. The attention to Public Image, particularly when controversial, symbolic and related to rhetoric missteps, aligns with a party's tendency to frame their political opponent as inappropriate or ineffective.

Conversely, Left and Center-left leaning articles prioritized the coverage of Climate & Energy, a theme which resonates strongly with Democratic priorities. California currently serves as a major model for progressive climate policy. With Newsom positioning himself as a leader on environmental legislation and clean energy transitions and ecological awareness, our findings point to the fact that Center-left outlets are more likely to cover these topics, and to do so in a positive tone. Notably, the Center-left sources also devoted substantial attention to Local Politics, which reflects the Democratic governance of California and reflects a stronger inclination towards institution-focused reporting, with Newsom at the head of it. This point is further highlighted with the finding that the coverage is done in a more neutral tone than most of the other topics.

Centrist outlets stood apart, displaying a most neutral tone and less evenly distributed coverage pattern. They occasionally mirrored Center-left sources (e.g. in their

interest in Climate & Energy), but the overall tone suggests a more descriptive than evaluative reporting of Gavin Newsom. They were also less engaged, with few articles overall and specifically in polarized topics like Immigration & Security.

Tone divergence was most significant in heavily represented topics such as National Politics and Public Image, where Left and Center-Left outlets had more positive sentiment regarding the governor while Center-Right and Right sources remained negative. These patterns highlight broad party dynamics: Democratic outlets are more likely to portray Newsom's national profile as promising, supporting his impact, whereas Republican-leaning outlets interpret the same development through a more critical lens, supporting their own representatives and opponents of Newsom. In contrast, topics such as Economy and Corruption & Scandal remained neutral to negative across most leanings, suggesting the topics' universally pessimistic nature.

The findings illustrate how political alignment continues to shape media coverage and in what light an issue or a person is presented. Newsom's identity as a Democratic governor puts him in the middle of opposing parties' agendas: liberal outlets foreground coverage that represent progressive achievements and conservative outlets emphasize domains where Newsom can be criticized. This pattern highlights the broader landscape of polarized media in the U.S, where audiences are exposed to selectively filtered portrayals aligned with political expectations.

Secondly, the collected news coverage of Governor Newsom is demonstrably linked to nation-wide political events, which serve as the primary drivers of the high-weighted terminology revealed by the TF-IDF analysis. Specific contemporaneous events - including Newsom's widely reported presidential aspirations, involvement in state gerrymandering with national implications, and attendance at an international climate conference - are central to this analysis. This correlation positions Newsom as a national actor, despite his gubernatorial role.

The significant similarity between the "public image" and "national politics" topic Tf-idf scores is directly attributable to national-level political posturing during the coverage period. This overlap is likely driven by Newsom's announcement of presidential aspirations. The media's focus on Newsom's potential national goals or role in the upcoming presidential cycle would naturally infuse his general "public image" articles with terms characteristic of "national politics," such as terms related to party politics, government, or opposition strategies.

The dominance of national terms in the Tf-idf results, particularly the persistent high weighting of "Trump", is another direct consequence of ongoing, high-profile conflicts and policy disagreements that played out on a national stage. This linguistic saturation indicates that the media frequently framed Newsom's actions and policies in

direct opposition or comparison to the former President - a framing which is a consequence of his presidential aspirations and frequent attacks on President Donald Trump.

The result of "local politics" being dominated by national-level terms is directly explained by two specific, contemporaneous events mentioned previously that forced state issues into a national context. First, the national conversation around gerrymandering/redistribution during this period - a state-level process with massive national implications in response to actions taking place in Texas - elevated the vocabulary. News articles discussing California's redistricting likely used terms like "redistricting," "republican," or "congressional map," which are weighted as national terms but appear in a "local" political context. In a similar manner the "climate and energy" category is dominated by national level terms. Newsom's international trip to the COP conference in Brazil is a tangible, non-state event that generates national/international vocabulary in the news. While the news is about the governor, the terms (e.g., "climate talks" "Brazil," "COP") are inherently national/global, thereby increasing the Tf-idf scores of national terms in the related category and consequently his total corpus.

In conclusion, the raw Tf-idf data - showing high term similarity across topic categories, the numerical dominance of national figures, and the nationalized vocabulary of news about a state governor - is not random. Instead, it is causally linked to the major, non-state events occurring during the coverage window. The media's response to Newsom's presidential posturing, direct engagement with national political opposition, and participation in international diplomacy elevated the usage of national-level terms, solidifying his perception and coverage as a major national political figure.

However, it should be noted that several factors complicate this analysis. First, the data captures only a one-month period during a particularly politically charged time, potentially amplifying national political themes that might be less prominent during routine governance periods. Secondly California's size and economic influence also naturally elevate its governor's national profile, making Newsom an atypical case compared to other U.S. governors. Moreover, not all categories follow the same pattern: the Corruption/Scandal category is dominated by California-specific terms (Williamson, Sacramento, Becerra), and Immigration and Security includes distinctly local markers such as "San Francisco" and "licenses," showing that state-level events still generate state-bounded discourse.

Conclusion

Throughout our study, we've highlighted the coverage of Gavin Newsom as highly polarized across political spheres. His impact revolves around a broad range of current topics, anchoring him as a global actor, deeply involved in all parts

of the politics in the U.S. Importantly, our study underlines the positive and negative bias of news outlets when depicting a politically engaged figure, even when covering the same events. Furthermore, it conveys the importance of specific events on the thematic focus of articles among varied sources.

The findings of this project could be strengthened with a larger and more comprehensive dataset. Due to timeline and access limitations, the dataset was heavily skewed towards certain publishers and political leanings. Furthermore, some major US news publishers (eg. CNN) were absent entirely. A more balanced view would be more representative of the American media sphere and strengthen the validity of our analysis, especially on segments (e.g. the intersection of Centrist articles and Social Issues) with few papers.

A second extension could consist of comparing the tonal and thematic coverage of other USA governors of varying political leanings in an attempt to describe a national trend. Moreover, the inclusion of international media sources could give insight into the political figures' coverage and image among a wider population.

Group Member contributions

The question formulation was conducted by all members. The typology and annotation of topics was completed through collaborative open coding and annotation. Interpretation & Communication (writing the report) was a collaborative process involving all the members. Philomène focused on topics and tone analysis & discussion and data sampling bias analysis. Maksymilian focused on the implementation, analysis and discussion of TF-IDF and LLM. Hillary focused on annotating tone and tone analysis. Paul focused on Data Collection.

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Appendix

LLM results:

Climate and Energy

“Newsom's climate coverage positions him as America's environmental ambassador, highlighted by his COP30 summit leadership while Trump was absent. The narrative celebrates California's renewable energy achievements and battery storage records while criticizing high energy costs and Amazon oil dependence. Articles frame him as Trump's primary climate antagonist, particularly on offshore drilling opposition, though conservatives dismiss his activism as performative amid affordability struggles. Coverage emphasizes tension between his global environmental leadership and practical challenges like union job displacement concerns and the political complexities of balancing climate goals with economic realities.”

Corruption and Scandal

“Corruption coverage centers on former chief of staff Dana Williamson's federal fraud indictment, creating political crisis despite Newsom not being implicated. Stories reveal Sacramento's political ecosystem rocked by FBI wiretaps, emphasizing Williamson's profanity-laced conversations and broader Democratic establishment implications. Coverage notes the ironic timing of scandals breaking during Newsom's climate leadership abroad and explores potential impacts on his 2028 presidential prospects. The narrative extends to immigration-related controversies like revoked commercial licenses, illustrating how scandal stories intersect with broader political battles over federal compliance.”

Economy Coverage

“Economic coverage presents challenging fiscal themes: budget deficits, high living costs, and business exodus concerns threatening Newsom's presidential ambitions. Articles highlight California's \$18 billion deficit and housing affordability struggles, with critics arguing progressive policies drove companies and residents to other states. Coverage contrasts ambitious social programs with fiscal implications, noting pension costs and mandated spending consuming resources. While acknowledging some positive developments like manufacturing tax incentives, the dominant narrative questions whether California's economic challenges—highest gas prices and regulatory

burdens—make Newsom vulnerable on bread-and-butter presidential election issues.”

Immigration and Security

“Immigration coverage depicts Newsom as a fierce sanctuary policy defender confronting Trump administration enforcement. Articles reveal battles over federal resistance, including lawsuits over masked agent bans and commercial license disputes resulting in federal funding threats. Coverage portrays Newsom standing firm against "authoritarian" tactics like troop deployments and raids, while critics argue his policies endanger safety by protecting criminals and unqualified drivers. The narrative frames conflicts as constitutional battles over states' rights versus federal authority, with Republicans using deadly immigrant truck driver crashes to attack sanctuary policies while Newsom maintains his approach reflects California values.”

Local Politics

“Local politics coverage reveals Newsom as a strategically savvy operator building national profile through California political dominance, notably via his successful Proposition 50 redistricting victory against Trump-backed efforts. Articles show masterful crisis management—wildfires, water issues, redistricting—while maintaining Democratic leadership position. Coverage explores his political mechanics: fundraising prowess, social media strategy, influencer engagement, and anti-Trump base mobilization. The narrative reveals party tensions with some donors sitting out campaigns and Democrats worried about positioning, while Republicans struggle with effective messaging against his local dominance and national ambition-serving moves.”

National Politics

“National coverage positions Newsom as emerging Democratic leader and 2028 frontrunner, with Proposition 50 redistricting victory elevating his profile as Trump's most effective antagonist. Articles reveal strategic use of California's influence to shape Democratic strategy—redistricting wars, climate leadership—while building donor and party relationships nationwide. Coverage analyzes his sophisticated media strategy including social media mastery and influencer engagement dominating news cycles. The

narrative explores California-Texas redistricting as Newsom-Trump proxy war, with Democrats viewing his anti-gerrymandering fight as needed leadership while positioning California as progressive federal policy alternative.”

Public Image

“Public image coverage reveals Newsom as master of political theatrics and social media warfare, particularly against Trump, where his polished presentation and strategic trolling made him a Democratic favorite while drawing praise for combativeness and criticism for narcissism. Articles show him leveraging major platforms—UN summits, Texas rallies—to build anti-Trump brand through photogenic appearances and crafted messaging. Coverage explores tension between aspirational rhetoric and governing realities, questioning whether style-over-substance and California’s polarizing image limit national appeal. The narrative highlights Hollywood relationships and celebrity criticism, focusing on his persona as both greatest Democratic asset and potential vulnerability for broader audiences.”

Social Issues

“Social policy coverage presents Newsom as progressive champion facing implementation challenges and political backlash over controversial policies complicating national ambitions. Articles reveal criminal justice tensions with voters passing Proposition 36 penalty increases while Newsom faces criticism for not implementing voter-mandated safety measures, highlighting progressive agenda versus public safety concerns disconnect. Coverage addresses contentious issues—transgender rights, reproductive healthcare, antisemitism, reparations—showing attempts to balance activist demands with political considerations. The narrative explores how policies like immigrant healthcare and justice reforms play differently with California’s base versus national audiences, with Republicans using initiatives to paint him as mainstream-value-disconnected.”